ENGLISH C2 · ADVANCED GRAMMAR

Dislocation, headers and tails

Use left and right dislocation to establish, recover or evaluate referents while maintaining a resumptive element inside the clause. The lesson connects form, meaning, register and real editorial decisions rather than treating the pattern as an isolated rule.

THE CENTRAL IDEA

Use dislocation, headers and tails to manage real-time topic accessibility and interpersonal stance in advanced spoken discourse while preserving the intended meaning and register.

Use left and right dislocation to establish, recover or evaluate referents while maintaining a resumptive element inside the clause.

MODEL

That proposal from the regional team, I cannot see it succeeding.

dislocated phrase + resumptive clause | complete clause + clarifying tail

6 GUIDED STAGES · 30 LEARNING DECISIONS

This complete guide combines explanation, visual reasoning, practice and feedback. Separate exercise and answer-key editions are also available from the lesson page.

LEARNING OUTCOMES

OUTCOME 1

01

Recognise the main dislocation, headers and tails patterns in authentic contexts.

OUTCOME 2

02

Choose a form that accurately expresses manage real-time topic accessibility and interpersonal stance in advanced spoken discourse.

OUTCOME 3

03

Avoid errors that change time, agency, emphasis or speaker commitment.

OUTCOME 4

04

Use the structure appropriately in conversation, interviews, oral storytelling and stylised dialogue.

Build meaning before form

Use left and right dislocation to establish, recover or evaluate referents while maintaining a resumptive element inside the clause.

What dislocation, headers and tails communicates

Use left and right dislocation to establish, recover or evaluate referents while maintaining a resumptive element inside the clause.

The central purpose is to manage real-time topic accessibility and interpersonal stance in advanced spoken discourse. A successful choice therefore preserves the proposition while making the intended relationship, viewpoint or degree of commitment visible to the reader.

That proposal from the regional team, I cannot see it succeeding.	a complex referent established before the clause
It has become remarkably influential, that early working paper.	a referent clarified or highlighted after a complete clause
The sheer scale of it, that is what surprised me.	an emotionally weighted topic introduced before identification

How the pattern is built

Use this working formula: dislocated phrase + resumptive clause | complete clause + clarifying tail. The formula is a decision path: it identifies the trigger, the clause architecture and the element that carries tense or modality.

The model “That proposal from the regional team, I cannot see it succeeding.” shows the complete pattern in context. Rebuild the sentence from meaning to form instead of translating each word independently.

Choice	Structure	Example
Left dislocation	topic phrase + clause with resumptive pronoun	That proposal from the regional team, I cannot see it succeeding.
Right dislocation	complete clause + tail phrase	It has become remarkably influential, that early working paper.
Affective header	evaluative phrase + resumptive clause	The sheer scale of it, that is what surprised me.

Choose by meaning, not by surface similarity

Neighbouring structures may contain similar words but perform different jobs. Compare the three reference patterns and name the intended effect before completing the sentence.

A reliable answer explains both why the chosen form works and why a plausible alternative would change the meaning, time relation, information focus or level of certainty.

Meaning	Best route
a complex referent established before the clause	Left dislocation
a referent clarified or highlighted after a complete clause	Right dislocation
an emotionally weighted topic introduced before identification	Affective header

Register, discourse and editorial control

This grammar is especially useful in conversation, interviews, oral storytelling and stylised dialogue. Its value comes from helping the reader process a relationship efficiently, not from making the sentence sound artificially complex.

After editing, check recoverability, natural word order and consistency with the surrounding paragraph. If the marked structure creates ambiguity, return to a fuller or more neutral clause.

Reason through the pattern

The visual map moves from communicative purpose to structural trigger, then to the final clause. It keeps meaning and form visible at the same time so the learner can justify every choice.

01	02	03	04
dislocated phrase	resumptive clause	complete clause	clarifying tail

DECIDE IN THIS ORDER

STEP 1

Decision 1

Identify the communicative purpose before selecting a form: manage real-time topic accessibility and interpersonal stance in advanced spoken discourse.

STEP 2

Decision 2

Locate the structural trigger and match it to one of the reference patterns.

STEP 3

Decision 3

Check time reference, clause relationships, agency and speaker commitment.

STEP 4

Decision 4

Read the complete sentence in context and confirm that its register suits conversation, interviews, oral storytelling and stylised dialogue.

STEP 5

Decision 5

Compare the result with a neutral alternative and keep the marked form only when it adds useful meaning.

Compare forms and meanings

Use the table to justify each structural choice.

Pattern	Form	Model
Left dislocation	topic phrase + clause with resumptive pronoun	That proposal from the regional team, I cannot see it succeeding.
Right dislocation	complete clause + tail phrase	It has become remarkably influential, that early working paper.
Affective header	evaluative phrase + resumptive clause	The sheer scale of it, that is what surprised me.

EXAMPLES AT A GLANCE

That proposal from the regional team, I cannot see it succeeding.	a complex referent established before the clause
It has become remarkably influential, that early working paper.	a referent clarified or highlighted after a complete clause
The sheer scale of it, that is what surprised me.	an emotionally weighted topic introduced before identification

COMMON ERRORS

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Do not omit the resumptive element when the phrase stands outside the clause.

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Do not mistake a right-dislocated tail for a restrictive modifier.

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Avoid dislocation in formal prose unless reproducing speech or creating a deliberate voice.

Recognition in context

Choose the sentence whose grammar matches the stated communicative purpose.

A1 · MEANING DECISION 1

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: a complex referent established before the clause?

OPTIONS That proposal from the regional team, I cannot see it succeeding. · It has become remarkably influential, that early working paper. · The sheer scale of it, that is what surprised me.

A2 · MEANING DECISION 2

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: a referent clarified or highlighted after a complete clause?

OPTIONS It has become remarkably influential, that early working paper. · The sheer scale of it, that is what surprised me. · That proposal from the regional team, I cannot see it succeeding.

A3 · MEANING DECISION 3

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: an emotionally weighted topic introduced before identification?

OPTIONS The sheer scale of it, that is what surprised me. · That proposal from the regional team, I cannot see it succeeding. · It has become remarkably influential, that early working paper.

A4 · INTERPRETATION 4

What does “That proposal from the regional team, I cannot see it succeeding.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS a complex referent established before the clause · a referent clarified or highlighted after a complete clause · an emotionally weighted topic introduced before identification

A5 · INTERPRETATION 5

What does “It has become remarkably influential, that early working paper.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS a referent clarified or highlighted after a complete clause · an emotionally weighted topic introduced before identification · a complex referent established before the clause

A6 · INTERPRETATION 6

What does “The sheer scale of it, that is what surprised me.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS an emotionally weighted topic introduced before identification · a complex referent established before the clause · a referent clarified or highlighted after a complete clause

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Form and function

Identify both the structural family and the meaning carried by each model.

B1 · FORM AND FUNCTION 1

"That proposal from the regional team, I cannot see it succeeding." uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Left dislocation / Right dislocation / Affective header · Gap 2: a complex referent established before the clause / a referent clarified or highlighted after a complete clause / an emotionally weighted topic introduced before identification

B2 · FORM AND FUNCTION 2

"It has become remarkably influential, that early working paper." uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Right dislocation / Affective header / Left dislocation · Gap 2: a referent clarified or highlighted after a complete clause / an emotionally weighted topic introduced before identification / a complex referent established before the clause

B3 · FORM AND FUNCTION 3

"The sheer scale of it, that is what surprised me." uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Affective header / Left dislocation / Right dislocation · Gap 2: an emotionally weighted topic introduced before identification / a complex referent established before the clause / a referent clarified or highlighted after a complete clause

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Guided discourse choices

Maintain accurate form and meaning across a connected sequence of decisions.

C1 · EDITORIAL PLANNING

Choose the model that expresses a complex referent established before the clause: _____. Choose the model that expresses a referent clarified or highlighted after a complete clause: _____. Choose the model that expresses an emotionally weighted topic introduced before identification: _____. Choose the model built with topic phrase + clause with resumptive pronoun: _____. Choose the model built with complete clause + tail phrase: _____. Choose the model built with evaluative phrase + resumptive clause: _____.

_____
_____

WORD BANK

Available forms

It has become remarkably influential, that early working paper. · That proposal from the regional team, I cannot see it succeeding. · The sheer scale of it, that is what surprised me.

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Open reconstruction

Recover the missing structural trigger without a word bank.

D1 · INDEPENDENT RECONSTRUCTION

That proposal from the regional team, _____. It has become remarkably influential, _____. The sheer scale of it, _____. State the full structural pattern for Left dislocation: _____. State the full structural pattern for Right dislocation: _____.

_____
_____
_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Controlled transformation

Rewrite the neutral source so that it performs the requested advanced function.

E1 · TRANSFORMATION 1

Rewrite “I cannot see the regional proposal succeeding.” using the Left dislocation pattern to express a complex referent established before the clause.

_____
_____

E2 · TRANSFORMATION 2

Rewrite “That early paper has become influential.” using the Right dislocation pattern to express a referent clarified or highlighted after a complete clause.

_____
_____

E3 · TRANSFORMATION 3

Rewrite “What surprised me was its sheer scale.” using the Affective header pattern to express an emotionally weighted topic introduced before identification.

_____
_____

E4 · TRANSFORMATION 4

Rewrite “I cannot see the regional proposal succeeding.” using the Left dislocation pattern to express a complex referent established before the clause.

_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Communicative production

Use the grammar independently in realistic academic, professional and conversational contexts.

F1 · PRODUCTION TASK 1

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Left dislocation to express a complex referent established before the clause, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

F2 · PRODUCTION TASK 2

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Right dislocation to express a referent clarified or highlighted after a complete clause, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

F3 · PRODUCTION TASK 3

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Affective header to express an emotionally weighted topic introduced before identification, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

Final self-check

Complete these prompts without reopening the guide.

R1 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: communicative purpose.

_____
_____
_____

R2 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: structural trigger.

_____
_____
_____

R3 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: meaning contrast.

_____
_____
_____

R4 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: register choice.

_____
_____
_____

Recognition in context

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

A1

That proposal from the regional team, I cannot see it succeeding.

Left dislocation is the best match because a complex referent established before the clause.

A2

It has become remarkably influential, that early working paper.

Right dislocation is the best match because a referent clarified or highlighted after a complete clause.

A3

The sheer scale of it, that is what surprised me.

Affective header is the best match because an emotionally weighted topic introduced before identification.

A4

a complex referent established before the clause

The Left dislocation pattern communicates a complex referent established before the clause.

A5

a referent clarified or highlighted after a complete clause

The Right dislocation pattern communicates a referent clarified or highlighted after a complete clause.

A6

an emotionally weighted topic introduced before identification

The Affective header pattern communicates an emotionally weighted topic introduced before identification.

Form and function

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

B1

Left dislocation / a complex referent established before the clause

The structure belongs to the Left dislocation pattern. Its communicative purpose is a complex referent established before the clause.

B2

Right dislocation / a referent clarified or highlighted after a complete clause

The structure belongs to the Right dislocation pattern. Its communicative purpose is a referent clarified or highlighted after a complete clause.

B3

Affective header / an emotionally weighted topic introduced before identification

The structure belongs to the Affective header pattern. Its communicative purpose is an emotionally weighted topic introduced before identification.

Guided discourse choices

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

C1

That proposal from the regional team, I cannot see it succeeding.

Left dislocation: topic phrase + clause with resumptive pronoun.

C2

It has become remarkably influential, that early working paper.

Right dislocation: complete clause + tail phrase.

C3

The sheer scale of it, that is what surprised me.

Affective header: evaluative phrase + resumptive clause.

C4

That proposal from the regional team, I cannot see it succeeding.

Left dislocation: topic phrase + clause with resumptive pronoun.

C5

It has become remarkably influential, that early working paper.

Right dislocation: complete clause + tail phrase.

C6

The sheer scale of it, that is what surprised me.

Affective header: evaluative phrase + resumptive clause.

Open reconstruction

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

D1

I cannot see it succeeding

Left dislocation requires “I cannot see it succeeding” in this model. topic phrase + clause with resumptive pronoun.

D2

that early working paper

Right dislocation requires “that early working paper” in this model. complete clause + tail phrase.

D3

that is what surprised me

Affective header requires “that is what surprised me” in this model. evaluative phrase + resumptive clause.

D4

topic phrase + clause with resumptive pronoun

Left dislocation is built as topic phrase + clause with resumptive pronoun.

D5

complete clause + tail phrase

Right dislocation is built as complete clause + tail phrase.

Controlled transformation

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

E1

That proposal from the regional team, I cannot see it succeeding.

topic phrase + clause with resumptive pronoun. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended left dislocation effect.

E2

It has become remarkably influential, that early working paper.

complete clause + tail phrase. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended right dislocation effect.

E3

The sheer scale of it, that is what surprised me.

evaluative phrase + resumptive clause. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended affective header effect.

E4

That proposal from the regional team, I cannot see it succeeding.

topic phrase + clause with resumptive pronoun. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended left dislocation effect.

Communicative production

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

F1

That proposal from the regional team, I cannot see it succeeding. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses topic phrase + clause with resumptive pronoun accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

F2

It has become remarkably influential, that early working paper. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses complete clause + tail phrase accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

F3

The sheer scale of it, that is what surprised me. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses evaluative phrase + resumptive clause accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

Diagnose the pattern, not only the score

Use this page to decide what to revisit in the complete guide.

CHECK · TRIGGER OR CONTEXT

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · AUXILIARY OR STRUCTURAL CHOICE

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MAIN VERB OR CLAUSE FORM

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MEANING AND REGISTER

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____